

These two co-eds were just like Daniel, good kids, smart kids. Because they were good kids, they were ashamed of how the credit card debt had mounted, too ashamed to tell their parents. Their separate stories ended the same tragic way. Suicide. All they left were apologies, along with the stack of credit card bills. The mothers were devastated to lose their children and devastated to learn what had brought on the despair. Imagine the grief and sheer agony for one of the mothers when, a few months later, the mailbox held a credit card offer in the name of her dead child, stating, “We want you back. 0% APR for six months.”

Nothing should make a person take such a drastic measure, ever. No mother should ever have to endure that kind of heartrending loss.

It’s a Mad, Mad World

Do not let your debts poison your life. Creditors do not own you. You may owe them some money, but you do not owe them your life. There is always a way out. These kids were too young to realize that. The two mothers went to Capitol Hill to testify that credit card companies should be banned from college campuses. As they waited their turn to speak, they were surrounded by credit card industry lobbyists and power brokers, discussing their golf scores and their campaign contributions. As these moms listened to the guys in the expensive suits, they became well aware that they were not operating on a level playing field. These moms had lost their children, due to the evils of the lending industry’s methods, and yet their words fell on deaf ears.

Good, decent parents with good, decent kids get trampled in the high stakes world of politics. Lawmakers’ deaf ears perk up only when the money starts talking. Elizabeth Warren, the Harvard Law professor and credit expert, is infuriated at how the financial industry can run amuck and ruin people’s lives. Laws won’t change because, she says in the PBS documentary *Secret History of Credit Cards*, “It is credit card companies who make big political contributions; it’s credit card companies who have been the number one givers in Washington. Not big oil, not big pharmaceutical – big consumer financial services. They’re giving money in Congress; they’re giving money in presidential campaigns. Why would they be giving so much money? What they